

Active Development of Respect for Diversity from Early Years in Serbia and Western Balkans



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Introduction

The chapter shows how the inspiration from one project for young children (Media Initiative) in one divided society (Northern Ireland) developed into a strategic approach in the Pomoc Deci organisation's work with children and adults in another divided society—Serbia and Western Balkans. It describes the path taken from one project, through the development of a four-year programme, its implementation and evaluation results, contributing to the overall new approach to programmes for children and young people of all ages, in the active development of respect for diversity in Serbia. The chapter also points out some of the strategic decisions taken and shows the conclusions based on almost 15 years of experience in developing programmes for the active development of respect for all differences among children and young people.

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"Peace cannot be kept by force; it can only be achieved by understanding... Our task must be to free ourselves from our prison by widening our circle of compassion to embrace all humanity and the whole of nature in its beauty." Albert Einstein

Abstract

This chapter will show how the inspiration from one project for young children (Media Initiative) in one divided society (Northern Ireland) developed into a strategic approach in the Pomoc Deci organisation's work with children and adults in another divided society—Serbia and Western Balkans. It will describe the path taken from one project, through the development of a four-year programme, its implementation and evaluation results, to the overall new approach for all the programmes for children and young people of all ages, in active development of respect for diversity in Serbia. The chapter will also point out some of the strategic decisions taken and will show the conclusions based on almost 15 years of developing programmes for the active development of respect for all differences among children and young people.

Background—the collapse of Yugoslavia and the challenges it created in Serbia

Serbia was part of a joint country (Kingdom of Serbians, Croats and Slovenians, Kingdom of Yugoslavia and Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia - SFRY) from 1918 to 1991, and its population was the largest among the constituents of the State (the last census data - held in 1991 in SFRY - showed that in Serbia alone, there were 9,791,500 inhabitants, out of 23,528,230 people in the whole State. The number of Serbian nationality people stood at 8,526,870). However, they did not live within Serbia only, so during the civil war (1991-1999), 750,000 refugees from Croatia, Bosnia

& Herzegovina and Kosovo & Metohija arrived in Serbia. Only around 50,000 returned to their original homes following the conflict.

Serbia was always a multi-ethnic and multi-religious society where different minority groups lived in different areas. In some places, they were a majority population, mostly close to the borders. In some towns close to the Hungarian border almost 95% of the population have been Hungarians; Close to Bulgarian borders the same percentage would be a Bulgarian ethnic group; In the south the Albanian population would make up the majority population at local level.

In total, there are 26 ethnic minorities living in Serbia. For eight of them, the whole education system, from Early Childhood Education and Care (ECEC) to University level, could be attended in the minorities' mother tongue, with Serbian language being taught as a foreign language.

The migrations during the civil war, and the war itself, with all its consequences, brought about huge polarisation among the ethnic and religious groups in Serbia. Three-quarters of a million people fled, or were made to leave their homes, in other former Republics of Yugoslavia. Serious segregation and animosity developed between these groups. The main divisions were between the Serbian and Croatian populations in the north and Albanian and Serbian populations in the south of Serbia. In addition, people arriving as refugees and internally displaced people also came with habits, styles of life, dialect, accent, and way of speaking the language from their own environment. Thus, frequently, they and their children were also not accepted by the local population. They were perceived as those who were "taking away" the little resources local communities had, under international sanctions imposed on Serbia during this period.

The challenge of bringing together these different groups was exasperated by the political decisions that did not allow the refugees and internally displaced people to get valid documents in Serbia—citizenship and ID cards. Therefore, they could not get regular employment, but were only recipients of social welfare. Over the years, this additionally caused friction between the “local” population on the one hand and refugees and internally displaced people on the other. The local population perceived the newcomers as a “burden” to their socioeconomic situation, already precarious due to the decline of the economy and sanctions.

Two more events marked this period: first, a change in the law on Preschool Education which prescribed one year of mandatory preparatory preschool programmes for all children, five and a half and six and a half years of age. This meant that all the Roma children who had never attended any organised nursery or kindergarten group joined the mandatory preparatory preschool programmes, often coming with no routine, social skills, or language. The other event was the introduction of Inclusive Education regulations which prioritised kindergarten and preschool groups that included all children, regardless of the type of disability that they may have. Given the already existing divisions based on the ethnic, religious, economic and language background, these changes were difficult to implement—especially children with multiple differences.

Pomoc Deci – Children and Youth Support Organisation

Pomoc Deci – Children and Youth Support Organisation (as its official name is in the English language) was founded in Serbia in 2004. Its mission is to create an environment of hope and respect for children and youth, where they have opportunities to achieve their full potential, and additionally, to provide children, youth, parents, and communities with practical tools for positive change. From the first days of operation until now, the organisation has been developing and

implementing various programmes for social inclusion through education, activism of children, and capacity building for children, their parents and teachers. In doing so, the organisation has been closely cooperating with kindergartens, preschools, schools, and other NGOs in the country, at European and global levels.

Our first projects aimed to empower young Roma children to integrate into the education system, especially in south of Serbia where Roma families speak only Roma language at home and their children have no Serbian language knowledge and skills when they are supposed to start their education. Since they were not attending any non-mandatory kindergarten or preschool prior to the first grade, they also lacked social skills, routine and all other elements needed for successful adaptation into school life.

In 2005, after the first contact with Early Years – the organisation for young children (NIPPA at the time), we found many common challenges and issues that we were both tackling – in Serbia, with the integration of Roma children, in Northern Ireland, with the Travellers. This brought about our partnership and the first joint activities. Trainers who were involved in the projects with Travellers’ children and families came to Serbia to train our volunteers, assistants and teachers, to share the experience and lessons learnt.

At the time, Media Initiative was already underway in Northern Ireland, so getting familiar with this initiative through discussions led to the development of initial training for the kindergarten and preschool teachers in using Persona Dolls and other tools to discuss emotions, differences and opportunities for acceptance of diversity among young children and significant adults around them (parents and teachers) in Serbia.

These actions, and many other supporting activities of Pomoc Deci, have led to several international awards for the best social inclusion programmes in south-east Europe and globally (ERSTE Foundation Award in

2009, Alcuin runner-up Award in 2017, one of 300 World Best Practices on Sustainability and Innovation for the 5th edition of the Global Entreprs Awards and 5Gcitizens International Congress in 2021).

Active development of respect for differences has become our overarching theme in everything we do, be it with very young children, their parents and teachers, with young people or other civil society organisations.

Over time, the organisation has developed different programmes for the prevention and overcoming of prejudice, stereotypes, and discrimination based on various types of differences with varied age groups of children and young people, starting from early years to young adulthood, and also with their significant adults.

New approach: active development of respect for differences in Serbia

Inspired by the Media Initiative programme in Northern Ireland and subsequent joint work on the development of the International Toolkit for the Development of Respect for Diversity with Young Children within the International Network for Peace Building with young children (INPB), Pomoc Deci analysed the situation in Serbia. We analysed available resources and approaches to peace building, respect for diversity and work with young children in this respect. We saw that most of the programmes available were developed for older children or teenagers, that those programmes were “dropped” down on those who were asked to just implement them, copied from other parts of the world. Most of the work was just project based, without sufficient thought about measures to sustain them within the communities into which they were implemented. So, we developed a new approach and new strategies for Serbia, and decided to start working accordingly with young children, their kindergarten and preschool teachers and parents. The core components and steps of our approach and process are hereby described.

Respect, not Tolerance

We were not going to use the term “tolerance” and would not promote it. We wanted to develop children’s understanding that differences exist everywhere and that they enrich the world, so they should be accepted and respected. Tolerance does not imply either understanding or accepting the facts. On the contrary, it implies being quiet and not reacting to what irritates a person or being able to deal with something unpleasant or annoying (as the word is defined in the Cambridge English Dictionary). Rather, we were aiming for conscious acceptance and respect for everyone.

Working with each child, whether a newcomer or already part of the group

Almost all traditional programmes for social inclusion of children, related to ethnicity, religion, different abilities, or socioeconomic background in Serbia, used to focus on the integration of these children in the majority group. They focused on the incoming child’s preparation to deal with the group into which he/she is coming. They were “preparing” a child entering a group (a “different” one) to integrate and find their way in the group.

We were convinced through both experience and knowledge that we needed to concentrate on each individual child – newcomers, as well as those already in the group. We aimed to develop understanding, acceptance and respect for another child – pointing out that each child is different in some way, but what matters is what similarities a child can find with another child at an individual level. At a group level, we also believed that it is the majority group that needs to be prepared to understand and accept the newcomers (not the other way round), focussing on the similarities whilst respecting the differences.

Cascading system of training

In a triangle family–child–early years setting, our strategy was to focus on the practitioners first, to build a strong group of future trainers. They could then work both with fellow preschool/kindergarten teachers and with parents, whilst they also work directly with children daily. This would enable us to reach as many settings, families and children as possible. The practitioners are the ones respected by both families and children for their knowledge, skills and care for children. They are the ones both children and adults turn to for help, advice and guidance.

Therefore, we chose to adopt a cascading system of training to reach as many settings, teachers, children and families as possible, but also in order to develop ownership and responsibility for taking the acquired knowledge and skills further to other colleagues among the trained practitioners. Developing a group of future trainers would serve as the basis for them to prepare and hold further training within their settings for their peers. Our further mentoring and support would focus on assisting the nuclear trainers to organise and conduct training for fellow teachers from other settings, municipalities and regions throughout the country. At the third level, those among the trained at secondary level who felt like engaging in further peer training and who showed capacity to do so, were then supported to become local focal points and local trainers.

Starting with (self)-assessment of attitudes and opinions of each teacher

To prepare the teachers for the process of transformation of their attitudes, opinions and behaviour on one side, to boost their self-confidence to change any negative attitudes and opinions among children and their parents on the other side, and to provide ourselves with the baseline data, we introduced the (self)-assessment tools and instruments. They were a litmus test for assessing the attitudes

and opinions of each teacher towards and about differences (ethnicity, religious, disabilities or socioeconomic background of children and their families). It was important to also assess the level of teachers' awareness about whether, and how much, children at the age of three notice differences in another child and whether it influences children's behaviour in the group. Individual semi-structured interviews were held with each teacher.

This approach provides us with data and input for adaptation of the training material later. It also has proven to be an eye-opener for many teachers, opening them up to a change in their own practice.

Parents reflect on their attitudes and opinions

We also needed to know what messages young children get about diversity at home, ie how much parents are aware that children notice differences in other children and that that can influence their behaviour towards other children. Additionally, we assessed how confident parents felt to change any negative attitudes towards difference already adopted by their child(ren).

For this purpose, individual semi-structured interviews were held with parents of the children in the kindergartens and preschool institutions where we were interviewing teachers. This was proving to be an important step towards attracting parents' attention to the ways they talk about differences. It also deepened their understanding of the level of their influence on children through everything they say to them or in their presence.

This step also encouraged parents to start discussing diversity related issues that they would not feel confident talking about otherwise, either in parental groups or with teachers.

Sharing the results with teachers and parents to show them where they are—and starting from there

The prevailing practice of NGOs is to use the results of assessments only for the organisational purposes related to the development of training, research or dissemination of the programme results. In contrary, we shared the results of the assessment of the teachers' and parents' attitudes and opinions about diversity with them first.

This approach proved to be very important in ensuring real interest from both teachers and parents to learn more about various topics related to the theme, reflect more on their own practices and to gain confidence to change both their own ways of thinking and their messages for children.

Interactive training for teachers as future trainers of other teachers

Although teachers in Serbia are well qualified (the minimum level of education required for preschool teachers is a post-secondary three-year college diploma in early years education), the content of their initial education does not reflect the most recent research and findings. Therefore, our approach included both teaching theoretical foundations and practical training. The contents, which were delivered in an interactive way, enabled the teachers to actively participate in the learning process and practice. They could use different practices in their everyday work whilst always putting the child at the centre of their focus.

The content of the training included both developmental aspects of children and behaviour at different stages, along with ways for responding to children's behaviours in different situations. The teachers received feedback not only from the trainers but also from peers. This approach increased their

skills of observation and giving constructive feedback to colleagues – something they were not used to in the traditional lecture-giving and receiving type of training. As a result, teachers gained not only knowledge and skills, but also the confidence needed to deliver their own future training to peers.

Piloting varied toolkits

Most teachers in Serbia are used to situations in which they are given just one set of tools and activities and are shown only one way of implementing them. Thus, we deliberately created a bit of confusion at first, by introducing three different toolkits and asking them to try them out in different situations. We asked them to try out different ways of approaching feelings of being excluded and include these in the play and group, different ways of tackling varied abilities and personal responsibility of each child for the peers in the group.

We provided mentoring support, organised discussion groups and enough room for them to voice their opinions on the effectiveness of different activities in their own environments. We provided them with feedback during the piloting process so that they gained both confidence and trust to openly discuss each element of the toolkits they had at their disposal.

This approach also taught them not to copy–paste any resource given to them. Rather, they were encouraged to use them as a starting point for the development of their own material, based on—and inspired by—the available material, adapted for the situation and environment at hand. It provided us, at the organisation, with practical knowledge about what works best in the Serbian context.

Teachers learn to (self) monitor and evaluate their actions and activities

Throughout the process of piloting various toolkits, our approach included training teachers to monitor and evaluate their own actions and activities. This approach empowered them for action research and self-reflection in their daily activities. As supporting material, we developed guidelines for teachers for action research in ECEC settings to determine the characteristics of- and address the exact challenges and specifics of any individual preschool group. This enabled adapting and introducing specific activities for the active development of respect for diversity among children and in work with parents. In the process of going through the cycles of implementation and self-monitoring, they became their own monitors.

Building a community of trainers and learners For sustainability reasons and to ensure continuous improvement in work on the development of respect for diversity in young children, we built a community of training and learning among teachers, both within an individual preschool and among all the participants in the project.

The approach meant building on the knowledge constructed in the group, based on the teachers' experiences, self-reflection, monitoring and evaluation of the effects of their work with children. We created an environment in which our trainers (a nuclear team of trainers that we developed along with some local trainers), as well as all the teachers, were equipped with knowledge, skills and attitudes to become a source of knowledge for learners.

Consequently, the participants in this group were capable and willing to be co-authors of the national guidelines for early years practitioners about the active development of respect for diversity among young children in Serbia.

The process was based on the concrete country's profile, experience during implementation, best practice examples and following the child-rights approach from the International Toolkit for Peacebuilding with young children.

Evaluation

In addition to documenting key events in the above-mentioned process and conducting ongoing reflection, we conducted a quantitative pre- and post-evaluation. We assessed changes in attitudes, opinions, confidence, and behaviour among all three groups—parents, teachers and children. We also investigated the level of understanding among teachers and parents of how much young children notice differences in others and themselves and their levels of self-confidence in their own capacity to influence children’s attitudes and opinions.

The changes in awareness of teachers and parents of how much young children notice differences are presented in Table 1.

As the table shows, the programme brought about statistically significant changes in the perception of teachers about the extent to which children notice differences in others (marked in red). The analysis of the data shows that about 30 percent of about 600 surveyed kindergarten/preschool teachers initially had thought that young children never or rarely notice differences in others. After the implementation of the programme, less than 14 percent of them kept this opinion, whilst about 14.5 more percent of the surveyed teachers understood that children notice differences all the time.

The changes in parents’ responses were not significant.

Table 1: To what extent do you think that young children tend to notice differences in others?

ANSWER	PARENTS		TEACHERS	
	PRE %	POST %	PRE %	POST %
Not at all	8.8	7.6	13.0	5.6
Rarely	12.4	12.1	17.4	8.3
Sometimes	32.3	34.5	26.1	30.6
Frequently	27.2	28.3	41.3	38.9
All the time	19.3	17.5	2.2	16.7

Table 2 presents the results regarding the perceptions of both parents and teachers of the children’s tendency to exclude children who they perceive as different from themselves. As the table shows, during the learning process, both parents and teachers understood that this tendency exists among young children.

Specifically, in the pre-pilot survey, almost 60% of the teachers thought that children never or rarely exclude other children from play or sharing toys. In the post-pilot survey,

around 35% of them kept this opinion, whilst around 24% of them changed their attitude and acknowledged that young children exclude other children in play or sharing toys. Furthermore, teachers came to realise that exclusion stems from negative perceptions of differences among children. This realisation motivated them to learn more and work with both parents and children to foster acceptance and respect of differences among children.

Table 2: To what extent do you think that young children tend to exclude other children because they are different from themselves?

ANSWER	PARENTS		TEACHERS	
	PRE %	POST %	PRE %	POST %
Not at all	22.4	14.3	21.7	13.9
Rarely	25.4	25.6	37.0	19.4
Sometimes	27.5	33.2	23.9	47.4
Frequently	18.1	19.3	17.4	19.4
All the time	6.6	7.6	0	0

Impact: national guidelines and development of new programmes in Pomoc Deci

An important outcome of the evaluation was the acknowledgment from the Ministry of Education of their long-term need to work on this issue. The programme served as the basis for the National Guide for active development of respect for diversity which was recognised as one of the needed resources for all kindergarten and preschool teachers.

The National Agency for Improvement in Education accredited our training programme for active development of respect for diversity in early years within in-service professional development requirements for kindergarten and preschool teachers. Thus, each preschool/kindergarten teacher who completed the training and showed evidence of appropriately implementing it in the six-month period after the training, would receive points towards licensing or re-licensing for

work in early years settings. Since the project's conclusion at the end of 2016, Pomoc Deci has provided training and support for teachers on an ongoing basis.

A long-term impact of the programme for the Pomoc Deci organisation itself has been the expansion of the programme for the active development of respect for diversity among school children, as well as young people. Based on the principles of our approach ie a child-rights and human-rights perspective, peer education and horizontal learning methods, the organisation has developed several training programmes, guides and toolkits that have been used in all the projects. In addition, the organisation has developed specific programmes for supporting parents directly.

These specific programmes assist in self-assessing one's own (un)conscious bias, prejudice and stereotypes and how to overcome them. The programmes support parents, older children and young people in the understanding of differences in themselves and others, to accept these differences and respect them.

Conclusions and hopes for future

It has been more than 15 years since Pomoc Deci first introduced the initiative for the active development of respect for differences in Serbia. And, it has been more than a decade since the EU funded project enabled a comprehensive development of the tools, materials, guides and training programmes. Furthermore, during this period, the international instruments for assessing the attitudes, opinions and self-confidence of teachers and parents to consciously work on the active development of respect for diversity in Serbia were adapted in Serbia.

To date, the political situation in Serbia and the region has threatened to develop and strengthen polarisations in society—politically, ethnically, and socioeconomically. Constant political tensions, especially in south Serbia, in the areas close to Kosovo and Metohija, affect all citizens, especially children and young people, and bring about a lot of violence, including armed incidents. Since the outbreak of COVID-19, the consequences of lockdowns have been also visible in children's lack of social and networking skills, adults' distancing and operating in closed circles.

The active development of respect for differences and all types of diversity proves to be of essential importance and is very welcomed by teachers, children, and young people in Serbia. Through the years, more than 80 teachers and almost 100 young people have been trained, mentored, and supported regularly to train their peers and colleagues. We hope to achieve a critical mass of trainers who could reach out to every kindergarten, preschool, primary and secondary school in the future. For lasting peace and stability in Serbia and the Western Balkan region, it is of crucial importance that the young children of today—and the future—understand and embrace differences and develop respect for all their peers and all people in the society around them.

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